

Nursing Care for Pets with Limited Mobility

Good nursing care can make the difference between a pet getting better or worse. Pets that cannot move well can develop **bed sores, pneumonia, muscle loss and urinary infections**. Keep them away from stairs and high furniture. When unsupervised, confine them to a small room or crate with room to turn around and stand if possible.

Bedding

- Soft bed with about **1 inch of padding per 10 lb** of body weight
- Pillows or rolled blankets to prop your pet upright or support the head; padding between the legs of large dogs lying on their side
- **Absorbent pads on top, waterproof layer underneath**
- Change bedding daily or whenever soiled; keep your pet **clean and dry**
- Check skin daily for redness or sores, especially over the hips, elbows and shoulders

Bathroom needs

Your pet may have trouble urinating while lying down or may not control the bladder. You may need to **express the bladder** (see our *Bladder Management* handout), and medications can help. Watch for less urine, blood or a strong odor and call us if you notice them.

Feeding

- Keep your pet **upright (sitting on the chest) while eating and for 15 minutes afterward**

- Pets with megaesophagus need special feeding instructions

Physical therapy at home

- **Turn** your pet every **4–6 hours** if they cannot move on their own (not needed overnight while you sleep)
- **Massage** each leg for **3–5 minutes** and gently rub the feet for up to 1 minute, several times daily
- **Toe pinch reflex:** gently squeeze between the toes to make your pet pull the leg back — **10 times** per leg
- **Assisted standing** several times daily for up to 1 minute, using a sling or harness under the chest and belly
- If the skin is healthy, **standing in water** makes your pet feel lighter and is good exercise
- **Go outside 3–5 times daily for 5–10 minutes** — important for mental health and bathroom needs. Use a chest harness, not a neck collar, and support the belly and chest to prevent falls.

Breathing care

Flat-faced breeds and pets with nerve or muscle disease are at risk of pneumonia.

- Let your pet rest in a steamy bathroom (hot shower running — **not** in the shower)
- Afterward, gently tap the chest with cupped hands (**coupage**) for 1 minute

Call us right away if your pet starts coughing, breathes fast (**more than 60 breaths per minute when not panting**) or has trouble breathing.